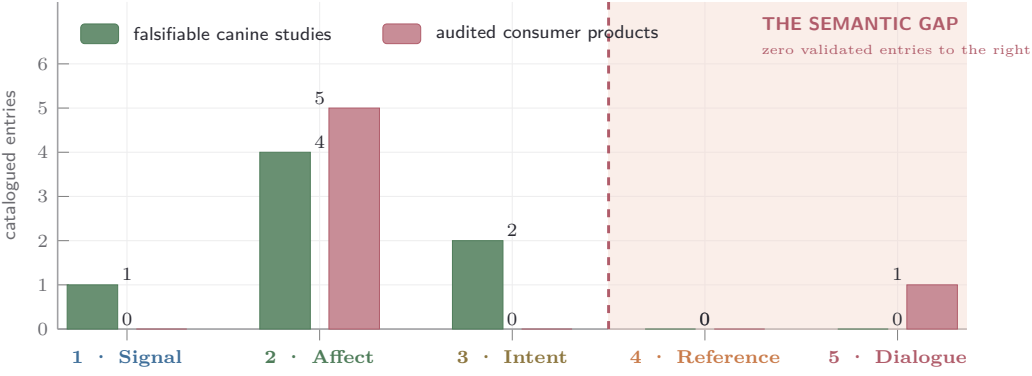evidence thickens below the gap, claims pile up above it